

By Anthony Fenech
Detroit Free Press

The first thing I'll remember about this season was the Saturday after the All-Star break when I was stopped in construction traffic driving home from the ballpark in Kansas City.

The Tigers lost, 4-1, and I was thinking about how months from now, when I write my fourth annual story about what I'll remember about this season, the only thing I'll remember was that it was the worst season ever.

This was on July 12.

That night, I ran into a few guys from out of town. One of them said that earlier in the day, they were sitting around at work calculating how many games the Tigers had lost over the past three seasons.

That night's loss was No. 255.

"That's a lot, man," he said. "A lot."

I merely write about the team. I'd venture to guess that for many people in the Tigers organization – especially those in the clubhouse who actually, physically lost those 114 games – this was the worst season ever for them, as well.

But the worst season ever is over. It ended on Sunday afternoon in Chicago. I was there.

Here, in chronological order, is what I'll remember from my fifth season covering the Tigers for the Free Press:

-- Watching Alan Trammell, who could have been anywhere else in the world, instruct middle infielders at an early spring minor-league mini-camp workout. "That's it?" he said later, after the final round of batting practice. "That's it for the day? Are you kidding me?" It was nearly 5 p.m. Walking off the field, he stopped to pick up a baseball beyond the right field fence. He saw more baseballs, so he picked up those, too, throwing them back onto the field. Soon, he was in left field. Eventually, after every single ball was picked up, a couple of clubbies picked him up on a John Deere and drove him back to the facility. What an ambassador for the Tigers, the game of baseball, and humanity. Alan Trammell is not just a Hall of Fame baseball player, he is a Hall of Fame person.

-- Watching Jordan Zimmermann walk aimlessly around right field during batting practice at Chicago's Guaranteed Ugly Field in late April. Zimmermann had just received good news – he did not need to undergo major surgery, which could have ended his career – but another lengthy rehabilitation was on the horizon. The frustration was evident in his voice when he spoke with reporters a short while earlier inside the Tigers dugout. No, Zimmermann hasn't pitched well in Detroit. Yes, you can consider his contract a bust. But nobody outside of these clubhouses will ever know the kind of lengths these players go just to stay on the field and the deep disappointment they feel when their bodies betray them.

- Receiving a text message from Jason Mize, Casey's father, asking how he pitched that night. He said he missed it because he was cutting the grass – usually Casey is

the one cutting the grass. That night, May 3, Mize threw a no-hitter in his first start for Double-A Erie. I knew damn well Jason Mize did not miss Casey's start – he doesn't miss any of Casey's starts – but I didn't ask and I wasn't going to let my assumptions get in the way of a good tweet.

- Spending a couple days with Colin Czajkowski, my 6th grade math teacher's son, the Gatorade High School Baseball Player of the Year in Michigan who didn't get drafted. It was a surprisingly intense look at the other side of the draft, especially at his parents, who agonized as the rounds went on, weighing college and money and their kid's dreams – most of all bummed because he was bummed. Czajkowski is doing OK: He was at Comerica Park with the Michigan baseball team last month when the Tigers honored the Wolverines for reaching the College World Series.

- Rolling up to Creighton's baseball field on a scooter for U-M baseball practice one day during the College World Series in Omaha, Neb. As I did, a handful of kids ran out on the field. When I pulled up, they moved their pick-up game to the adjacent softball field. Sitting there, watching like a weirdo, I served as their honorary umpire for an inning. They were the kids of U-M baseball staffers – assistant coach Nick Schnabel's kid can hit – and at a time in which I felt like I was rapidly losing love for the game, it was awesome to rewind back to those days when backyard baseball was all that mattered.

- Covering U-M in the College World Series, which was hands down the best part of the season. I thought I was going to be in Omaha for a weekend and they kept me there for nearly two weeks. The kids, their parents, the coaches. ... The camaraderie, the brand of baseball, the winning. ... That was my Cooperstown trip of the 2019 season and I'm thankful my editors allowed me to stay in Omaha to cover it. College baseball is the best and the Wolverines' emergence – led by head coach Erik Bakich – will be very impactful for Michigan high school baseball and also for the in-state collegiate competition it will create.

-- When John Hicks caught the first pitch from his mother, Karen, with tears in his eyes on Pink out the Park night. Karen has battled breast cancer throughout Hicks' career and fought tears herself before delivering a strong throw. Hands-down the best moment of the season. Hicks wasn't the only Tiger affected by the disease: Former bench coach Steve Liddle's wife, Anne, is a breast cancer survivor. Liddle, who is someone you'd enjoy hanging out with, retired at the end of the season. Congratulations on an awesome career.

-- Sitting in the corner of the Tigers dugout at Angel Stadium of Anaheim leading up to the July 31 trade deadline. Playing on the West Coast created an unusual situation: The 1 p.m. deadline coincided almost exactly with game time. At 12:59 p.m., Nick Castellanos appeared in a Tigers uniform for the last time. There was a lineup card taped to the wall with his name on it, hitting second. When I walked out of the dugout, Castellanos was standing near the bat rack. While I waited for the elevator, I heard Castellanos had been traded to the Cubs. I got off at the concourse,

hurried down to the first row and saw Jordy Mercer – who was not in the starting lineup – standing in the on-deck circle. Soon, I could confirm Castellanos had been traded to the Cubs. I'll remember watching Castellanos walk out of the Tigers' clubhouse and what he said when he did. This year's trade deadline – from those frantic few minutes and the hours inside the press dining room afterwards to beating the sunset at Seal Beach for dinner with former Free Press Sports Writer John Lowe – went down as a Top 5 baseball reporting day.

-- A conversation with Tigers public address announcer Jay Allen, just days after he had been diagnosed with stage 4 bile duct cancer in mid-August. I spent the drive home in tears that day, so in awe of the grace he showed and perspective he had in talking about an unspeakably cruel twist of fate. Allen, 59, began chemotherapy shortly thereafter, but still finished his rookie year behind the mic while commuting from Grand Rapids and back. Jay's Crazy Cancer Journey Benefit is scheduled for Nov. 2 at English Hills Terrace in Comstock Park. Check out these links for more information on the charity benefit or to donate to Allen's GoFundMe page to aid assistance with medical and living expenses.

-- Pumping gas one night in my hometown, when a man with a mustache pulled into the Tim Hortons drive thru in a black pick-up truck. I yelled, "Yo!" then again, louder. He drove through to get coffee – it was 1 a.m. and they were closed – but George Sipple came back and had a beer with me at the Final Score. I love George, I missed him a lot this year, and his absence in our Tigers coverage was notable.

- I'll remember being back in the Houston Astros clubhouse the next day, for exactly 23 minutes, with my name all over the Internet for being blocked from entering the Astros clubhouse by three security guards the night earlier. You can say whatever you want about me or my coverage, which has placed in the Top 10 in the Associated Press Sports Editors' highest circulation beat writing competition. But you cannot say I don't ask tough questions or shy away from taking the heat for what I write.

- I'll remember lying to my Lyft driver that night about what I do and where I'm from. He wore an Astros hat and given his line of questioning in picking up 'Anthony' outside of Minute Maid Park, I suspect he put 2-and-2 together, that this guy wearing a jacket and tie in 95-degree heat wasn't really a baseball fan in town from Chicago to watch the Tigers and Astros. When I got to my hotel room, I turned on the television to ESPN and saw on the bottom line that I was being namelessly referred to as a Detroit Free Press reporter with unethical behavior. I'll remember I couldn't stop thinking about this: That was the journalistic equivalent of a beat writer coming out and accusing a player of using performance-enhancing drugs.

-- A late-night meal off Lafayette with a laid-off professional scout from the area who was in town visiting his family for personal reasons. The guy oozes baseball passion, most evident in Detroit, where he helps lead the charge to bring the game to inner-city kids. He has played, coached and scouted professionally and internationally.

That a person like him, for as much of a baseball lifer as one can be in their mid-30's – and the scores of other accomplished scouts with even more experience – cannot find a job is part of the sadness of today's game. Now, front offices are far too populated with cookie-cutter personalities: Young, mostly white guys who play follow-the-leader and don't bleed the game, which has devolved into a home run hitting contest.

-- The last Sunday in Chicago, where the worst season ever ended at the same place my first season ended in 2015. It had to end there, in the rain, at that stadium, inside the uncomfortable press box located down the first base line with the big window open. The last postgame clubhouse of the season is a beat writer's final exam of sorts – we're all ultimately judged on the relationships we build. Every year, there are different emotions, but if you're good, they're there. This year, the faces were much less familiar – only one player remains from the start of my tenure – and many relationships were strained. It ended up being a pretty full year, but it could have been much worse: I could have walked out of the clubhouse and felt nothing at all, no sadness that the worst season ever had finally ended.

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Before I go somewhere far away for a long time and consciously avoid watching even one second of postseason baseball – the games will start at 3 a.m. there, anyways – I want to go on a rant with a bunch of hot takes.

I love baseball. But I really hate baseball right now, and it's not because of the Tigers. The game is boring as hell. The game is bad. The game is not really much of a game anymore. I love baseball.

On a fundamental level, it boils down to the baseball itself. The baseball is the entire game. When it changes like it has – I remember Eno before he was Eno asking the Commish about it at the 2016 Winter Meetings – it carries inherent risk, such as ...

It's the baseball. It's absolutely the baseball. And I don't think we've seen this drastic impact until three years later – and we won't see its maximum impact for years to come – because teams and players and technology have quickly exploited that change.

The year is 2019. If they would have changed the baseball in 1999, it might have taken 10 years to catch up technologically. The game is too “smart” now, there is too much money at stake, and the cause-and-effect is expedited because of it.

I’m not convinced the change was made in bad faith – five years ago, pitchers were dominating, nearly to a breaking point – or that Major League Baseball knew the extent of the implications because of that change.

-- Crying on my drive home that evening. I wanted another job, guys. I knew they didn’t want me, but I sent another follow-up e-mail earlier in the day, and on that drive home I wondered why. T

I’ll remember watching Nick Castellanos walk out of the visitors clubhouse at Angel Stadium of Anaheim, minutes after he was traded to the Cubs. I won’t repeat the phrase he used, but Castellanos was very excited. Sure, he was jumping from last-place into a pennant race, but Castellanos was most excited because Cubs assistant general manager Jed Hoyer had just told him on the phone how much they wanted him. I now wonder if he had ever once heard those words in his six years with the Tigers. I saw a lot of myself in Castellanos this season. I think he is a hell of a hitter, introspective, emotional, very smart, and received a bad rap locally because he’s always been the kid. It is not surprising at all to see what he’s done with the Cubs, and with the way they have taken him in, it would not be surprising at all to see him stay there.

I’ll remember the tears that welled up in my eyes as I watched Jordan Zimmermann – injured again – walk aimlessly around right field during batting practice at Guaranteed Rate Field in Chicago in late April. Zimmermann had just received good news – he did not need to undergo elbow ligament reconstruction surgery, which could have ended his career – but another lengthy rehabilitation was on the horizon. The frustration was evident in his voice, speaking to reporters a short while earlier. No, Zimmermann hasn’t pitched well in Detroit. Yes, you can consider his contract a bust. But nobody outside of these clubhouses will ever know the kind of lengths these players go just to stay on the field and the deep disappointment they feel when their bodies betray them. A year earlier, Zimmermann – who is a stand-up guy, tough as nails and remotely funny at times – was the subject of likely my most regretful moment on the beat. Riding a spring training sugar high a year earlier, I tweeted something sarcastic in relation to one of his nagging injuries. It filtered back to him. We talked about it. It took me nearly seven months, but I finally apologized. I knew better than that, and I hope you will know, too: Criticizing a player for their performance or behavior is fair game; criticizing them for injuries is not. Publicly, I would like to apologize to Zimmermann for a third time.

I'll remember when my fifth season unofficially started, in fantasy camp in early February. For the record, my sports editor, Chris Thomas, thought fantasy camp was some kind of prospect camp, so he wasn't thrilled when he saw me down there having the time of my life, playing baseball with the older folk. But I was not in a state of mind to apologize: I promised myself that I was going to have fun this year, come hell or high water. A year earlier, fantasy camp director Jerry Lewis mentioned participating in the camp and writing a story about it, so I took him up on it. I'm glad I did. It was a blast and I met a bunch of awesome people, some of whom I consider friends, others whom have even pointed me in a certain direction for stories. Maybe I shouldn't have let the world know how much fun I was having, and I understand the perception of posting pictures wearing the uniform of the team I cover. But I am confident in my integrity and felt the only way to cover the event was to do it all-in. I was there to write a story on fantasy camp. The Free Press paid for my hotel during the camp. At a time when I was struggling to find an identity, the fun I had at fantasy camp was the best thing that could have happened.

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I'll remember a late-night meal at Green Dot Stables with a laid-off scout who was in town visiting his mom, who recently had been diagnosed with lung cancer. The guy oozes baseball passion, most evident locally, where he keys efforts to bring the game to inner-city children. The Tigers have been extremely sub-par in this area. The guy has experience playing, coaching and scouting professionally. At his previous job, he had recommended multiple All-Star players before they broke out, to no avail – I saw the texts to the general manager. That a person like him, for as much of a baseball lifer as one can be in their mid-30's, cannot find a job is part of the sadness of the modern game, whose front offices are far too populated with cookie-cutter personalities, young, mostly white guys who play follow the leader and do not bleed the game. Sitting at the bar, he told me to see it through: He could still hear the passion for the game in me, which I hadn't felt all year.

- I will remember three phone calls I received. The first on May XX made me cry. The second, a couple hours later, surprised me: Was he really that mad about that story that he would go out of his way to tell PR that he won't talk to me? The third, months later, on the afternoon of Aug. 4, came from former Tiger Rod Allen. It came randomly, while I was in a fit of rage.

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I will remember three phone calls I received. The first, in mid-May, made me cry like a baby. Everything happens for a reason, they say, and though I don't know if I necessarily believe it, I can see it, and I hope it does. The second, hours later, surprised me: Was Justin Verlander really that mad about that story that he would go out of his way to tell Astros PR he won't talk to me? The third, a week later, explained why I had lost nearly 15 pounds since the start of the regular season, always felt tired and already burned out. I am proud to report that I have gained that weight back, have felt energized the past month and am closing in on the great shape I was in to start the season.

I'll remember Michael Fulmer providing a breath of fresh air inside the Tigers clubhouse upon his visit right before the All-Star break. Fulmer's personality was missed in the clubhouse this year. I think it's a stretch to say the elbow ligament reconstruction surgery was a good thing, but the timing of it, right before his family's baby boy was born, was a silver lining. Fulmer showed up lighter than I remembered him: If he can continue slimming down, it will bode well for his return.

I'll remember running the Alex Bregman-for-Michael Fulmer information up the ladder in spring training, and the chain reaction it caused. Tigers general manager Al Avila called a meeting with his front office. Avila told an assistant to call the pro scouts. The team, essentially, freaked out. I shouldn't have teased them about having it, but I was going to have fun this year, so I did. I can keep a secret – the best reporters do – but after I found the second person that I needed to report it a few weeks later, I knew it was only a matter-of-time. I eventually let the secret out on Aug. 4. We probably should have included this in the story, but every transaction that was mentioned had a high-level source from both teams attached to it. You can only lead a horse to water. ...

A 20-minute wait later – 99% of journalism is waiting, John Lowe says – I got Castellanos for a few minutes before the rest and lost most of my “scoop” when the voice memos on my iPhone SE stopped. Six or seven hours later, I emerged from the press dining room and beat the sunset to Seal Beach,

I'll remember sitting in the corner of the Tigers dugout at Angel Stadium of Anaheim leading up to the 4 p.m. trade deadline on July 31. Playing on the West Coast created an unusual situation: The deadline would coincide almost exactly with game-time. Sitting in the dugout during that time, I was unsuccessful getting information about the Tigers' trade with the Braves involving Shane Greene. The longer you do this, the more closely you pay attention to how the sausage is made. The time elapsed between when the trade broke and when the return was reported by an out-of-towner was curious to me. That my sources on all sides were not responding sent a chill down my spine. This would be part of a Top 5 baseball reporting day: Minutes before the deadline, Castellanos emerged in the dugout, in full uniform. I put my head down and soon, I couldn't find him. I received a tip about a Cubs trade. I was

able to confirm it and tweeted it out five or 10 seconds later than the big boys. It was at this time, in that dugout, when I decided that I was no longer playing this game. I don't want to be a national baseball reporter; it could take 10 years to make up those 10 seconds. I want to use my voice – to hell with the scoops – so I spent the next seven hours in the media dining room, dozens of texts, at least a half-dozen phone calls – one was an hour and 13 minutes long – in letting it be heard.

I'll remember sitting on the pier at Seal Beach later that night, and how free I felt watching the sunset. A trip there and dinner with former Free Press sports writer John Lowe was the perfect tonic to what was a transformative trade deadline. I remember holding up dinner for five minutes to apply for a video game writing job before the midnight Eastern deadline, and, after our dinner, wondering why. These dinners and conversations with John are among the most treasured of my life; he is a charger for the baseball beat writer's battery. And if I never get another opportunity to say this, I want to urge people who have more influence than me to nominate John for the J.G. Spink Award after late Boston Globe writer Nick Cafardo and Dallas Morning News writer Gerry Fraley. I say this with 100 percent conviction: John was the consummate baseball scribe, with a steel trap of a mind, ultimate professionalism, and among the greatest of appreciations for the game and its history. He taught me most everything that I know about this job, and though I consistently fall well short of his standards – I was most embarrassed for the Verlander situation in August to reach John – I am indebted to him for molding me in the relationship-building ways he was brought up on. It was – as longtime Detroit News columnist Lynn Henning enjoyed retirement in Georgia – undoubtedly the most enjoyable dinner experience of my season.

I'll remember that one day I got mad online. I've taken pride in my career for not getting mad online, and I regret the depth of my madness. I don't feel right apologizing for it – I think there are certain lines you don't cross as competitors – but I will say this, as non-descript as I can: My competitors on the Tigers beat are among the most hard-working in the industry. They arrive early, stay late, and some of them do not miss any morsel of daily news. In another overwhelmingly losing season, I have been in awe of how some of them consistently they answer the bell and cover baseball in which the games don't matter.

I'll remember how it all started, by seeking out Astros third baseman Alex Bregman inside the home clubhouse at Minute Maid Park, first on Monday, then on Tuesday, to seek any comment on the trade that could have sent him to the Tigers two seasons ago. Waiting for Bregman on Tuesday, Justin Verlander arrived at his locker and two local reporters approached. With nothing to do, so did I.

-Hitting rock bottom, missing a flight, Amazon job fair

I'll remember the phenomenon of viral fame and how weird it was. As I spun through the news cycle that day, I tried to disappear more and more. Deleted

Facebook, went private on Instagram, avoided Twitter, ignored dozens of calls and hundreds of text messages. I'll remember the support I received from family and friends, the Free Press, fellow reporters, players I've covered and people around baseball. Most notably, I'll remember an e-mail from one person specifically, which finally got me. Thank you.

uncomfortable it was. As I spun through the news cycle that day, I tried to disappear more and more. Around noon, I de-activated my Facebook. After the game, I lied to my Lyft driver about what I do and where I'm from. Given his line of questioning in picking up 'Anthony' outside of Minute Maid Park, I suspect he put 2-and-2 together, that this guy wearing a jacket and tie in 95-degree heat was not just a baseball fan in town from Chicago to watch the Tigers and Astros. At some point during that day, I realized that some people have to deal with this every day of their public lives, how exhausting that must be, and wondered about the psychological impacts of it. Perhaps that is why Verlander opposed my solar eclipse tweets so vehemently; not because I made him look like a nerd, but because in the one place he expected privacy, he wasn't given it. Unfortunately, we could never talk it out. When I got back to my hotel room, I turned on the television and saw me referred namelessly on ESPN's bottom line as a Detroit Free Press reporter with unethical behavior. I'll remember I couldn't stop thinking about this: That was the journalistic equivalent of me coming out and accusing someone of using performance-enhancing drugs.

No. 1 – Casey Mize

The skinny: (Brief about the player's season, potential, etc.)

2019 stats:

Why he's important:

